Gupta was an inspiration to Rajwar herself. Like her, she too studied at the National School of Drama (NSD). "The first time I saw a celebrity was when she visited the NSD campus. I remember she was wearing a lovely red outfit," says Rajwar. "We used to all look up to her. So in awe was I that I couldn't even go and talk to her." Soon their paths would align in then Bombay as Rajwar arrived to kick off her acting career. The duo would first work in a play, *Surya ki Antim Kiran se Surya ki Pahali Kiran Tak*. "She is the first person who ensured we were paid well for rehearsals and the play," says Rajwar. "Every time I was down [professionally], something worked out with her." Rajwar would work as an assistant creative head in Gupta's production house and managed her daughter, Masaba, for a year.

"*Kaam hi toh karna hai* [One just has to work]," says Gupta of her role in assisting Rajwar in her professional journey. "She has done a lot. *Koi bhi kaam chhota nahin hota* [No work is small]. She is proof that if you work hard and consistently, you will reach where she has. She has been to Cannes." Rajwar plays a key part in India-set UK drama *Santosh*, which was the UK's submission to the best international film category at the Oscars. But it's her work in the TVF shows, *Gullak* and *Panchayat*, that has made Rajwar a familiar face. "They have changed my life," she says. ■

—Suhani Singh

SHORT FILM ▼

BLOOD IN THE KITCHEN

RENUKA SHAHANE'S *LOOP LINE* IS A SOBERING FEMINIST TALE WHICH USES ANIMATION TO GOOD EFFECT

In a startling sequence in actor-director Renuka Shahane's animated short film *Loop Line*, a homemaker makes pakoras out of her brain and serves them to her husband and his friends while they drink and chatter noisily. No, this is not a horror film. *Loop Line* is the sort of poignant feminist cinema Shahane has honed over her last two features, *Rita* (2009) and *Tribhanga* (2021).

***Loop Line* follows a woman compelled to be voiceless at home, while her indifferent and brutish husband stays blind to her. Titled in Marathi as *Dhawpatti*, it was screened at the New York Indian Film Festival on June 21.**

"The protagonist keeps slipping into her fantasy world, and I initially wanted these portions to be animation while reality could be live action," says Shahane. "But I realised, the audience wouldn't experience the story properly then, so I chose to tell this through animation." The *Dhawpatti* title has multiple meanings. "It means a runway, which allows airplanes to pass, but we focus on the planes, not the runway," says Shahane. "It also means parallel lines. The protagonist is living parallel lives: one at home, one in her fantasies."

The animation—done by Mumbai's Paperboat Design Studios—forces you to notice the sound design of the protagonist's mundane chores: sweeping the floor, making roti. It also helps drive home the point in the bloody scene with the brain. "A lot of homemakers feel their job doesn't require brains, their opinions don't matter," explains Shahane. "In that scene, the men feasting on alcohol and *chakna* are blind to her, her brain, her soul, but only notice her when her sari's *pallu* drops. Then, she is a piece of meat."

The protagonist is also kept silent because, "the moment I give her a voice, the spell of her being voiceless breaks", says Shahane. Forever challenging herself with new mediums, she is now working on a Marathi feature about caste and a black comedy in which she plans to cast her husband Ashutosh Rana. ■

—Shanu Ghosh



FEMINIST TAKE Renuka Shahane; (below) a still from *Loop Line*

